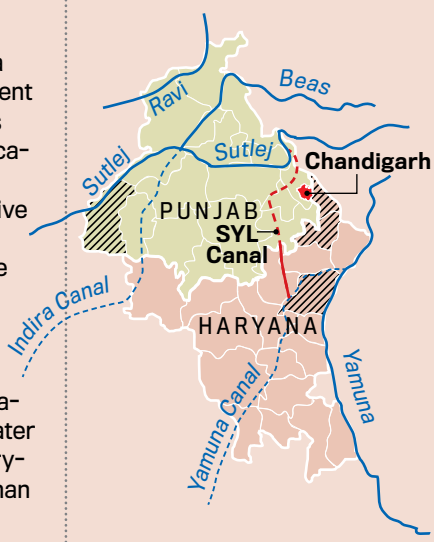
PUNJAB'S CLAIMS

- Transfer of Chandigarh along with the Punjabi-speaking areas in Haryana
- Abandon Sutlej Yamuna Link (SYL) canal project
- Annul Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB)'s February notification that nixed Punjab's exclusive right to appoint a member to the board
- Control of all headworks and dams; remuneration for river water flowing into Haryana and Rajasthan
- Control of all gurdwaras in the country under unified Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee

THE SYL CANAL DIVIDE

Haryana wants Hindi-speaking areas like **Abohar** and **Fazilka**

Punjab wants Punjabi-speaking areas in **Ambala, Panchkula** and **Karnal**



SYL CANAL
— 90 km in Haryana
-- 121 km in Punjab

HARYANA'S COUNTER

- State also has right on Chandigarh; also claims Hindi-speaking areas in Punjab
- 85 per cent work on SYL is complete, Punjab should finish work on its side
- Punjab must share water, as stipulated by several tribunals
- BBMB notification should be revoked and Haryana's quota of sending one member to the board must be restored
- A separate gurdwara management committee for the state

Shiromani Akali Dal, looking to spring back into reckoning after the assembly poll rout, was the first to react, pushing Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann to escalate the issue further and pass the resolution at a specially convened session. Mann also threatened protests from the "streets to Parliament" against the implementation of central civil services rules in Chandigarh.

Chandigarh is a sensitive issue for the Sikh-majority state, which lost its original capital, Lahore, during Partition and has not had a capital of its own since. Chandigarh, goes the overriding sentiment, was built to compensate for this loss.

The capital, though, is not the only sore point for Punjab. Besides making Chandigarh the provisional capital of both Punjab and Haryana for 10 years, many Punjabi-speaking areas too were awarded to Haryana, adding insult to injury as it were. Further, the Punjab Reorganisation Act gave central agencies the control of irrigation water. In his speech in the assembly, Mann made a passionate appeal for the immediate transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab along with the Punjabi-speaking areas in Haryana, though he kept quiet on other contentious issues.

Back in January 1970, the Union government reportedly gave the nod to Chandigarh going to Punjab. Haryana was given five years to construct its own capital as well as a liberal Rs 10 crore grant for the purpose. This was linked to the transfer of Punjabi-speaking areas in Haryana to Punjab and the reciprocal transfer of Punjab's Hindi-speaking and Hindu-dominated Abohar and Fazilka regions to Haryana. However, the provisions were unacceptable to both sides and the dispute festered. Chandigarh then was made the provisional joint capital of Punjab and Haryana under the same Punjab Reorganisation Act, with the two states contributing government staff in a 60:40 ratio, respectively. But since the negotiations were not going anywhere, Chandigarh was accorded UT status in 1976.

Over the years, with the UT making its own recruitments, the number of Punjabi employees declined but the Punjab civil services rules continued to apply. While IPS and IAS officers held posts in a similar ratio from these cadre, the seniormost bureaucrats came from the AGMUT (Arunachal, Goa, Mizoram and UT) cadre.

In 1984, under the shadow of the Sikh insurgency, the Punjab governor was made administrator of Chandigarh. About a year later, the then prime minister Rajiv Gandhi negotiated a deal with H.S. Longowal, who was heading the Akali Dal. Less than a month after the July 1985 accord, Sikh militants opposed to it assassinated the Akali chief. Political parties in Haryana too were opposed to the accord as they blamed the then Congress state government for entering into a vague agreement, especially regarding the territories to be transferred to Haryana in lieu of Chandigarh.

Later, the Centre formed commissions for the transfer of territories, including one under the then Supreme Court Justice E.S. Venkataramiah in 1986. Assigned to define Hindi- and Punjabi-speaking villages, the judge recommended exchange of some 70,000 acres of land. But neither Punjab nor Haryana agreed, and the transfers never took place.

The Justice J.C. Shah-led Punjab Boundary Commission as well as other reports also upheld Punjab's right over Chandigarh, but the state's politicians were not willing to relinquish claim over Hindi-speaking areas and give them to Haryana. Over the years, the issues of water-sharing vexed